

## Handout 5.7: Backstitch and Whipstitch Steps

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Period: \_\_\_\_\_

**Directions:** Fill in Part 1 during the slides. Part 2 is the backstitch step card. Part 3 is the whipstitch step card. Each step has one action and a picture described in words, so you can work from the sheet alone. Part 4 is the self-check and picking the right stitch.

### Word bank in Spanish

| English          | Spanish                  |
|------------------|--------------------------|
| seam             | costura                  |
| strong           | resistente (fuerte)      |
| edge             | borde                    |
| join             | unir                     |
| back (backwards) | hacia atrás              |
| over             | por encima               |
| layer            | capa                     |
| backstitch       | pespunte (puntada atrás) |
| whipstitch       | puntada sobrehilada      |
| basting          | hilván                   |

### Part 1: Three stitches, three jobs

**Draw the side view.** Draw what the thread does when you look at the cloth from the edge.

|                |            |
|----------------|------------|
| Running stitch | Backstitch |
| (draw it)      | (draw it)  |

Look at your two drawings. In the running stitch, how much of the seam has no thread across it? \_\_\_\_\_

Why does that make it weak? \_\_\_\_\_

**Name one job for each stitch.**

| Stitch         | One job it is right for |
|----------------|-------------------------|
| Running stitch |                         |
| Backstitch     |                         |
| Whipstitch     |                         |

## Part 2: Step card, the backstitch

Say it with me while you sew: **back into the last hole, forward one.**

**Step 1. Knot your thread and come up at point 1.** Bring the needle up from underneath, on the marked seam line, about half an inch in from the edge. Picture: cloth seen from above with a marked line running across it, and a needle coming up through the line with a knot underneath.

**Step 2. Go down one stitch length behind point 1.** Go backwards. Put the needle down about a quarter inch behind where you came up, on the line. Picture: a needle going down into the line to the left of the first hole, with a short arrow pointing backwards.

**Step 3. Come up one stitch length ahead of point 1.** Bring the needle up on the line, about a quarter inch in front of the first hole. Picture: the needle emerging on the line to the right of the first hole, with a short arrow pointing forwards.

**Step 4. Go down into the last hole.** Put the needle down into the last hole you came up from. The first time, that is the Step 1 hole. That is the move that makes it a backstitch. Picture: a needle pointing into an existing hole in the cloth, with the thread from the previous stitch lying in the line.

**Step 5. Come up one stitch length ahead again.** Same distance every time. Keep the stitches on the line. Picture: the needle coming up further along the line, the finished part behind it looking like one solid line of thread.

**Step 6. Repeat Steps 4 and 5 to the end of the seam.** Back into the last hole, forward one. Every time. Picture: a solid unbroken line of stitching two inches long on a marked line.

**Step 7. Check the top.** Look at the top of your line. A backstitch has no gaps. If there are gaps, you skipped Step 4. Picture: two lines of stitching side by side, one solid with no gaps, one dashed with gaps, and a check mark over the solid one.

**Step 8. Finish off.** Three tiny stitches in one place on the back, then a knot, then trim close with the snips. Picture: the back of the cloth with three small stitches on top of each other and snips cutting a tail.

## Part 3: Step card, the whipstitch

**Step 1. Stack the two pieces and line up the edges.** Put one piece of felt on top of the other. Line up the two edges so they match exactly. Neither edge sticks out past the other. Picture: two rectangles of felt, one on top of the other, with one edge lined up as a single straight line.

**Step 2. Pin them.** Two or three pins. They go in across the edge, with the heads sticking out so they are easy to pull. Picture: two felt pieces held edge to edge with three pins crossing the join.

**Step 3. Knot the thread and come up through both layers.** Bring the needle up through both pieces near the edge, about an eighth of an inch in. Picture: a needle coming up through the doubled edge with a knot hidden between the layers.

**Step 4. Take the needle over the edge.** Go over the top of the joined edge, not through it. Picture: an arrow looping over the top of the joined edge from one side to the other.

**Step 5. Come back up through both layers, a quarter inch along.** Enter from the same side you started on, a quarter inch further down the edge, at a slight slant. Picture: a slanted stitch crossing over the top of the edge, like a small bar laid at an angle.

**Step 6. Repeat, keeping the same slant and the same spacing.** The finished stitching looks like a row of matching slanted bars over the edge. Picture: five or six evenly spaced slanted stitches marching along a joined edge.

**Step 7. Check for daylight.** Look at the join. If you can see between the two edges, your stitches are too far apart. Go closer together. Picture: two joined edges, one closed tight, one with visible gaps, and a check mark over the closed one.

**Step 8. Check both layers.** Open the pieces gently. If they come apart, your needle missed one layer. Restitch that part. Picture: two hands pulling gently on either side of a stitched join that stays closed.

**Step 9. Finish off.** Three tiny stitches in one place, between the layers where they will not show, then a knot, then trim. Picture: snips trimming a thread at a stitched edge with the tail tucked between the two layers.

#### Part 4: Self-check and stitch selection

**4a. Self-check.** Circle one number in each row for each stitch. 1 means not yet. 3 means good.

| What I am checking                | Backstitch                | Whipstitch                   |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------------|
| Even stitch length                | 1 2 3                     | 1 2 3                        |
| Straight line, or even slant      | 1 2 3                     | 1 2 3                        |
| No puckering; the cloth lies flat | 1 2 3                     | 1 2 3                        |
| Extra check                       | Top has no gaps: yes / no | Both layers caught: yes / no |

**4b. Pick the stitch.** One sentence of reasoning each.

| The job                                                         | The stitch | Why |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|------------|-----|
| The shoulder seam of a bag that will carry books                |            |     |
| Closing the last two inches of a stuffed pouch from the outside |            |     |



|                                                                         |  |  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|--|
| Holding two pieces together<br>just long enough to sew the<br>real seam |  |  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|--|

**Exit card (tear off or write on an index card)**

1. Why a running stitch is not strong enough for a seam, in your own words:

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

2. My self-check numbers: backstitch \_\_\_\_\_ ; whipstitch \_\_\_\_\_

3. Name something in your own closet that needs a fix. Which of the three stitches would fix it?

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_